

GRIMES COUNTY COMMISSIONERS COURT

OFFICIAL MINUTES — WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 12, 2026

The Grimes County Commissioners Court met on Wednesday, August 12, 2026, at 9:00 A.M. Members Present: County Judge Joe Fauth, Commissioner Chad Mallett, Commissioner David Tullos, Commissioner Michael Raska, Commissioner Phillip Cox.

County Judge Joe Fauth called the meeting to order.

— Regular

Call to Order

Public Comments

We look forward to hearing from the citizens of Grimes County. If you wish to make public comments you will need to submit a Public Participation Form prior to the start of the meeting and give it to the County Clerk. Public comments will be limited to 2 minutes per person.

County Judge Joe Fauth made a public comment addressing Facebook concerns about burning operations for the TeraFab project. Judge Fauth reported that TeraFab and its contractor maintain a twenty-four hour daily watch, monitor weather and wind reports, and refrain from burning during unfavorable wind conditions. He noted that the contractor keeps burn piles small to minimize ash spread, maintains multiple water trucks on scene for dust control and fire suppression, and operates within well-defined containment areas. Judge Fauth stated that dispatch, emergency management services coordinator Dion Bumpus, and the Iola fire department have been notified of the burns in their response area. He acknowledged a recent smoke complaint occurred during cloud cover conditions that naturally held smoke down, and he confirmed that the contractor has been maintaining at least a five-hundred foot clear line from the burn piles. Judge Fauth shared this information with both the commissioners and the public to address concerns and prepare commissioners for potential citizen calls on the matter.

Grimes County District Clerk - Diane LeFlore (JF)

- 1 Receive and accept Order reappointing Jessica Murphy as the Grimes County Auditor with a term of office beginning October 1, 2026, and ending September 30, 2028. — Diane LeFlore, Grimes County District Clerk**

Diane LeFlore District Clerk reported that the courts had received a reappointment order for County Auditor Jessi Murphy as Grimes County Auditor for the term beginning October 1, 2026, and ending September 30, 2028, which was signed by both district judges Gary Cheney and David Mormon and filed in the district clerk's office as required by statute. County Judge Joe Fauth confirmed that no motion was required and that the order was acceptable, offering congratulations to County Auditor Jessi Murphy on the two-year extension.

Grimes County Sheriff's Office - Chief Deputy Martha Smith (JF)

- 2 Discuss and take action to approve 2 new Jail Sergeant positions for the Grimes County Jail. — Martha Smith, Grimes County Sheriff's Office**

County Judge Joe Fauth presented a request from the Grimes County Sheriff's Office to approve two new jail sergeant positions for the Grimes County Jail. Human Resource Director Atina Adair indicated that the office was discussing salary ranges in the three to four range and noted that candidates had not yet been identified, meaning positions could potentially be filled from outside or through internal promotion. County Judge Joe Fauth clarified that the office needed to determine whether the positions would be filled by promoting current jailers or hiring from outside, as this

would affect budget implications and whether the action constituted a grave public necessity under statute. County Auditor Jessi Murphy explained that adding positions to the current fiscal year 2026 budget would require the court to deem the action a grave public necessity for an unforeseen emergency, whereas the positions could be added without such a declaration if included in the fiscal year 2027 budget. County Judge Joe Fauth indicated that Chief Deputy Martha Smith had originally presented the request as necessary to meet Texas Commission of Jail standards, given that the office currently had only one of two budgeted sergeant positions filled, a vacancy that had existed since July, requiring jailers on off-shifts to call sergeants for information. Commissioner Chad Mallett noted that if the positions involved promotions, the court could work to find resources, but if outside hires were contemplated, the funding situation was less clear. The matter was discussed at length, but the court ultimately decided to take no action at this time and instead direct the Sheriff's Office to proceed with filling the existing vacant sergeant position through the normal hiring process, with further consideration of the two additional positions to occur during the fiscal year 2027 budget discussion.

Grimes County Judge - Joe Fauth III

3 Discuss and take action on any issue regarding FY 27 Proposed Budget. — Joe Fauth III, Grimes County Judge

County Auditor Jessi Murphy presented detailed changes to the FY 2027 budget following discussions with various departments. She reported reallocating IT expenses for the fire marshal to fund 63, reducing the Fire Marshal Fire Inspector software line by \$7,002.41 and the IT computer hardware line by \$2,965 to cover a computer and monitor, with the cell phone line reduced by \$675. All these amounts were added to fund 63 with the same line items created there. Murphy met with representatives regarding direct victim expenses and reallocated the existing \$25,000 across ten different line items, including lodging for \$8,000, dining for \$5,000, food and drink stock for \$2,500, fuel for \$2,000, transportation for \$2,500, repairs and maintenance for vehicles for \$1,200, clothing and grooming for \$1,500, beneficiary card assistance for \$1,100, security locks for \$500, and a communication line for \$700, maintaining the total at \$25,000. County Judge Joe Fauth and the court discussed at length the budget grand totals under different scenarios, including one removing the SpaceX revenue of \$10,000,000, which resulted in a \$12,869,414.55 deficit, and another adjusted scenario including removal of the fairgrounds capital project, reduction of nondepartmental contingency by \$1,800,000, reallocation of IT expenses, and addition of two replacement ambulances, which with the \$10,000,000 in revenue would leave a \$1,700,000 excess. Murphy walked the court through multiple salary increase scenarios ranging from a \$4 increase across the board to fixed rate and percentage options, with the court ultimately moving toward discussion of a dollar 15 COLA with merit-based increases and adjustments to bring part-time employees to minimum wage levels. The discussion was substantive and wide-ranging, touching on capital project funding, ambulance purchases, constable staffing, tax rates, and numerous budget line items across multiple departments.

Signature

Joe Fauth III, Grimes County Judge

DATED: 08/05/2026

ADJOURN

A motion to adjourn the meeting was made by Commissioner David Tullos, seconded by Commissioner Michael Raska. Carried (5-0-0).

1:05 PM

THE OFFICIAL MINUTES OF THE GRIMES COUNTY COMMISSIONERS COURT ON August 12th, 2026, ARE HEREBY APPROVED.

County Clerk Barbara Kimich